

Better Neighbourhoods

2012 to 2014

Participatory budgeting in Reykjavik



**CITIZENS
FOUNDATION**

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What is Better Neighbourhoods?

- **Participatory budgeting in Reykjavik, capital of Iceland from 2012 to 2014**
- 300 million ISK (1.9+ million EUR) allocated each year for ideas from citizens on how to improve the different neighbourhoods of Reykjavik



What is Better Reykjavik?

- **All year idea gathering and prioritisation by citizens for the City of Reykjavik**
- **Every month 10-15 top ideas in 10 categories are moved into city administration for processing**
- Citizens are informed on website and in email with reasons for decisions



Better Neighbourhoods process

1. **Citizens submit their ideas**
2. City of Reykjavik evaluates their cost
3. **Citizens vote on the ideas**
4. City of Reykjavik executes them
5. **Citizens use the results**

1. Citizens submit their ideas

- **Citizens submit ideas for projects they think will improve their neighborhoods**
- Using subsites on Better Reykjavik e-democracy website
 - 10 subsites, one for each neighbourhood
- Authentication with Facebook Connect or email / password for this phase
 - **Easy access gives more participation**





HOME



IDEAS



DEBATE



CATEGORIES



FEED

When an idea is added to Better Neighborhoods it needs to fit the following criteria:

Improve the environment, better the playtime abilities and transport for pedestrians and cyclist.

The idea also needs to within the scope of the city, fit in with its planning and should not need complicated and/or wide-ranging preparataions and coordination with other institutions or entities.

Submit a new idea**Idea title - 80 characters left****Select category****Description - 500 characters left**

Explain your idea in a few paragraphs and try to capture its essence clearly.

Why should people support your idea?**Add a point in support - 60 characters left****Explain your point - 500 characters left**

A strong point is important to convince other people to support or oppose your idea. Explain why people should vote on this idea, what makes it important or not.

All fields are required

1.b What kind of ideas?

- **Improve the environment, facilitate playing, improve pedestrian and cycling transport**
- Within scope of the city, fit planning, not complicated nor need wide ranging preparation and coordination
- **Over 500 ideas sent in by citizens in 2014**

2. City evaluates costs of ideas

- City of Reykjavik Construction Board evaluates costs and feasibility of each project
 - **164 ideas of +500 deemed eligible for voting**
 - A necessary step but also one that gives city employees much power over the outcome
 - Real transparency is needed for this step



3. Citizens vote on the ideas

- **The vote is electronic, binding and secure**
- **78 ideas were voted in by citizens in 2014**
- One vote per person is ensured by strict authentication
- The voting process is detailed later on



4. City executes the ideas

- **Some ideas are realized in a few weeks**
- **Other ideas take over a year**
 - **Depends on many factors**
 - Number of departments and people to be involved
 - Planning regulations
- **Over 200 ideas already executed**



5. Citizens use the results

- **From benches to footpaths to dog parks to better lighting to playgrounds**
- **More trees, trashcans, repair pavements, food gardens, add speed bumps or pedestrian lights**
- Improvements from Better Neighborhoods are easily found in all areas of the city of Reykjavik











Citizens process in voting

- **It's a binding vote in four steps**
 - a. Authentication**
 - b. Choose a neighbourhood to vote in**
 - c. Choose projects to vote for**
 - d. Vote**



Voting for projects in Reykjavík boroughs

11. - 18. Mars 2014

The voting is in four steps:

1 AUTHENTICATE

2 SELECT BOROUGH

3 CHOOSE PROJECTS

4 VOTE RECEIVED

Click the button below to start



a. Authentication

- **Strict authentication**
 - **Using IceKey (Icelandic National Registry or**
 - **Electronic IDs embedded in debit cards**
- As it's a binding vote with real money the authentication has to be secure, one vote per person



Íslykill

Kennitala:

2707634999

Íslykill:

.....

Íslenskir sérstafir:

á ð é í ó ú ý þ æ ö

Smelltu hér til að panta íslykil

Staðfesta

Rafræn skilríki



Settu kortið í lesarann

Lesu skilríki

b. Choose a neighbourhood

- **You choose any neighbourhood you like**
- **But you can only vote in one of them**
 - **Most people vote in their own but some vote for friends or relatives ideas**

1 AUTHENTICATE**2** SELECT BOROUGH**3** CHOOSE PROJECTS**4** VOTE RECEIVED

You can only vote on projects in one borough

Choose a borough by clicking on the map



c.1 Choose your projects

- You can choose one project and vote for that
 - **This is strategic voting and gives that project more weight**
- **Or you can fill your budget quota**
 - Which is a good exercise in how budget really works



1

AUTHENTICATE

2

SELECT BOROUGH

3

CHOOSE PROJECTS

4

VOTE RECEIVED

Árbær

0,0 used, 27,5 left

27,5 millions ISK budget

Select projects by clicking a name below

Project name	Amount in millions	Project name	Amount in millions
A Light footpath from Bæjarháls to Árbæjarstífla dam	8,5	I Picnic tables and benches near ball field by Bugða, Norðlingaholt	2,0
B Install roundabout at Bæjarbraut/Hraunbær	15,0	J Improve Árbæjartorg square, with picnic tables, benches and more	3,0
C Install lighting for ice skaters, by the sand beach at lake Rauðavatn	3,0	K Install more benches and litter bins along footpaths in Árbær	3,0
D Pave the bridge over Elliðaár river - close to Fylkir Stadium	1,0	L Repair basketball fields south of Hraunbær 62-70, by Rofabær	6,0
E Fitness equipment in area by Bugða - near Kólguvað, Norðlingaholt	5,0	M Install footpath at Hraunbær/Rofabær/Fagribær intersection	3,0
F Light footpath from Bröndukvísl to Fiskakvísl	5,0	N Renew a playground between Álakvísl and Silakvísl	12,0
G Improve footpath and limit speed in Bugða, at Kólguvað	3,0	O Install off-leash dog park - location yet to be decided	5,0
H Repair sledding slope in Selás	2,0	P Lay gravel footpath from Búðavað to Björnslundur, Norðlingaholt	3,0

[Vote](#)

c.2 Improvements cost money

- **When you choose a project you can see your budget being spent**
- The horizontal box above the projects gets filled up as you choose projects



1

AUTHENTICATE

2

SELECT BOROUGH

3

CHOOSE PROJECTS

4

VOTE RECEIVED

Amount used and amount left

Árbær

A

Budget box starts to fill up

8,5 used, 19,0 left

You do not have to use the whole sum

Select projects by clicking a name below

Project name	Amount in millions		Project name	Amount in millions	
A Light footpath from Bæjarháls to Árbæjarstífla dam	8,5		I Picnic tables and benches near ball field by Bugða, Norðlingaholt	2,0	
B Install roundabout at Bæjarbraut/Hraunbær	15,0		J Improve Árbæjartorg square, with picnic tables, benches and more	3,0	
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Project A has been selected

Vote

Vote button is active

c.3 Educating the voters

- **The interface shows clearly that with a budget you can't have everything**
- When you have chosen a project the ones you can't choose anymore are grayed out



1

AUTHENTICATE

2

SELECT BOROUGH

3

CHOOSE PROJECTS

4

VOTE RECEIVED

Árbær

A

K

M

F

19,5 used, 8,0 left

You do not have to use the whole sum

Select projects by clicking a name below

Project name	Amount in millions
A Light footpath from Bæjarháls to Árbæjarstífla dam	8,5
B Install roundabout at Bæjarbraut/Hraunbær	15,0
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Vote

c.4 Filling your budget quota

- **Most people try to fill their budgets**
 - You don't have to but most of us feel we should use all our options when voting
- This can be done with few projects or many



1

AUTHENTICATE

2

SELECT BOROUGH

3

CHOOSE PROJECTS

4

VOTE RECEIVED

Árbær

B

N

27,0 used, 0,5 left

You do not have to use the whole sum

Select projects by clicking a name below

Project name	Amount in millions	
A Light footpath from Bæjarháls to Árbæjarstífla dam	8,5	
B Install roundabout at Bæjarbraut/Hraunbær	15,0	
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Vote

1

AUTHENTICATE

2

SELECT BOROUGH

3

CHOOSE PROJECTS

4

VOTE RECEIVED

Árbær

A	K	M	F	E	H	D
---	---	---	---	---	---	---

27,5 used, 0,0 left

You do not have to use the whole sum

Select projects by clicking a name below

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Vote

d. Voting

- **Just press the Vote button**
- You can vote again, as often as you like
 - This makes it very hard for others to control your vote
 - **Only the last vote counts**
- You can change neighborhoods



1

AUTHENTICATE

2

SELECT BOROUGH

3

CHOOSE PROJECTS

4

VOTE RECEIVED

Thank you!

**Your vote has been received
and you have been logged out.**

You can vote as often as you like while the vote is open,
from 11. to 18. of Mars. Your last vote is the one that counts.

[Click here
to vote again](#)

Voting integrity ensured

- **Three separate well defined roles with different entities responsible for each role**
- **Voting fraud impossible except through a conspiracy of at least two entities**
- Reykjavik city Internal Audit monitors the process
- **External experts do a security audit every year, before, during and after the voting**



Voting roles

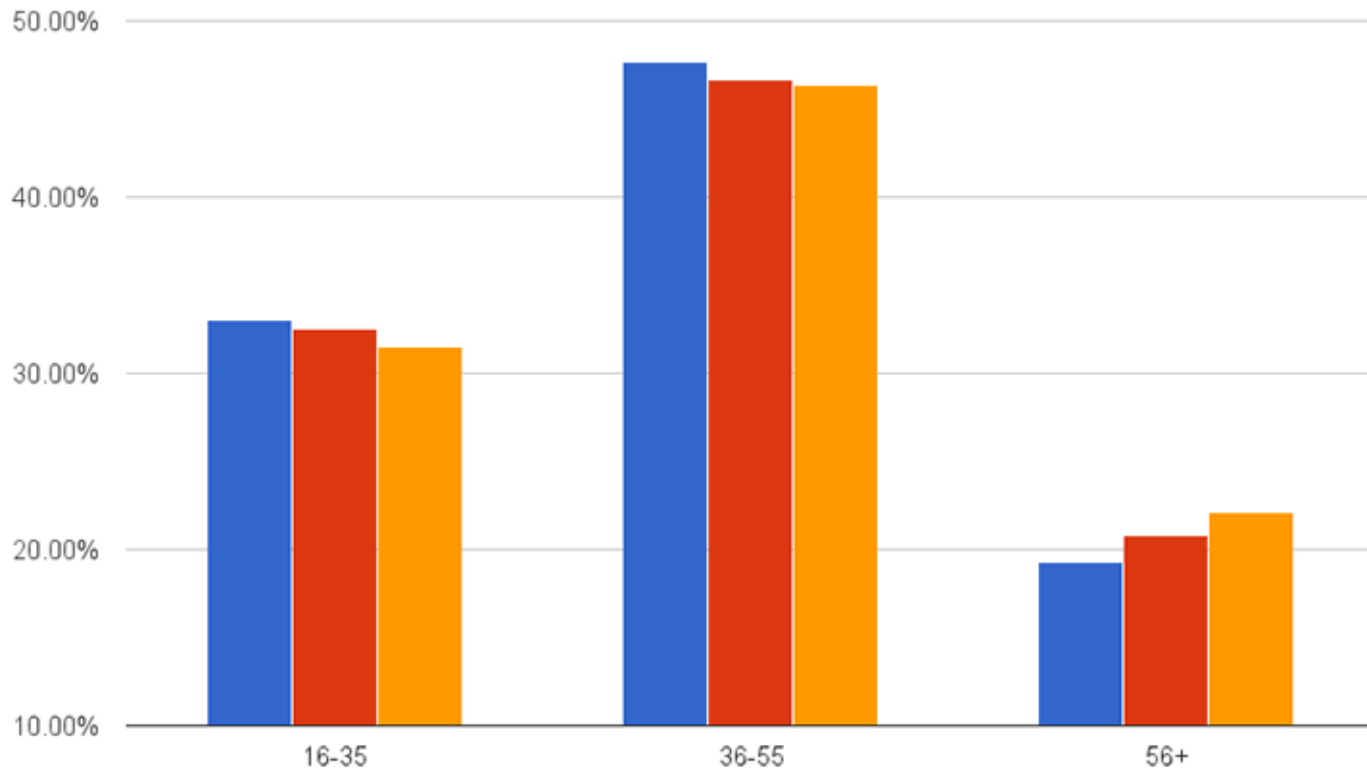
- **Citizens Foundation writes the software**
 - Assists verbally with setup, when needed, but without touching any computers used in the vote
- **City of Reykjavik - Runs the election**
 - Servers, various processes
- **National Registry does authentication**
 - Offers anonymous voting



Participation statistics

- **313 ideas have been approved by citizens in Better neighborhoods from 2012 - 2014**
- **Ideas per year**
 - 2012 - 124
 - 2013 - 111
 - 2014 - 78
- Bigger projects get approved every year

Voters, age groups in %



Year Voters

- 2012 - 6.506
- 2013 - 6.077
- 2014 - 5.505



Participation goes down

- **Youth participation is low**
- **Worrying downwards trend for past 3 years**
- **This is more than lowered participation in most established democracies**

Non-participation reasons

- **From user interviews**

- **Too little influence on the city budget to bother**
- **Only smaller projects, not bigger issues**
- **Many people don't know about the project**
- **Projects offered not interesting enough**
 - Many don't realize that it's citizens ideas



A technical success

- **Our voting system worked very well, no problems occurred**
 - **Easily adapted to other kind of e-voting, mostly a matter of changing the voting page itself**
 - (Open Active Voting - <https://github.com/rbjarnason/open-active-voting>)
- Security experts from a third party observer could find no fault in our software



Authentication is a barrier

- Over 75% of visitors to our voting website go away on authentication page
- **The need for proper authentication is one of the biggest barriers to online voting**

Negative issues

- **Users confuse Better Reykjavik with Better neighborhoods**
 - Very different rules and format
- **Better neighborhoods used resources that could have gone into Better Reykjavik development**
 - Much effort spent on trying to get the city to support more development with little results

Suggested improvements

- **Increase the budget that citizens decide on instead of a decrease (inflation)**
- **More real life meetings to create interest**
 - Hard to get people to show up for those though
- **More PR is needed, many people don't know about the project or how it works**



A great success

- **Over 200 citizens have suggested ideas that are now a reality**
 - Hundred more are in process
- **Thousands of citizens of Reykjavik have had a real influence on their surroundings**
- All neighborhoods of Reykjavik have been improved visibly through Better Neighborhoods

Citizens Foundation highlights

- **500.000** unique visitors since 2008, over 250.000 in 2013
- **70.000 citizens out of 120.000 inhabitants have used Better Reykjavík** which is an official and active collaboration with the City of Reykjavik

Active Citizen 3D



YOUR PRIORITIES



CITIZENS FOUNDATION

Better Alamance

No trolling please



- **Two levels of defense**

- **Prioritization of ideas and points ensures that junk sinks to the bottom where no one sees it**
- Users can notify admins about ideas and points
 - **Admin can easily remove offending content and warn the user that is responsible**
 - Users get 3 warnings and are banned on the 4th



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Thank you